Transportation as a Modifiable Pathway in Neighborhood Disparities in Mental Health Diagnosis: Evidence from a Five-County Philadelphia Survey

American Association for Community Psychiatry

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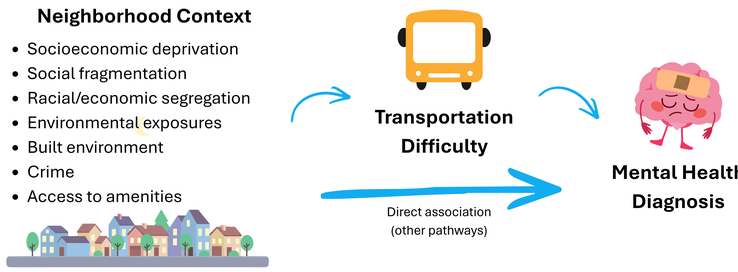
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BACKGROUND

- Neighborhood disadvantage is linked to poorer mental health.
- The pathways driving these disparities remain unclear.
- Transportation may be one modifiable pathway (Kirkbride et al., 2024).

OBJECTIVE

To identify **neighborhood mental health disparities** and examine transportation as a potentially modifiable pathway.



METHODS

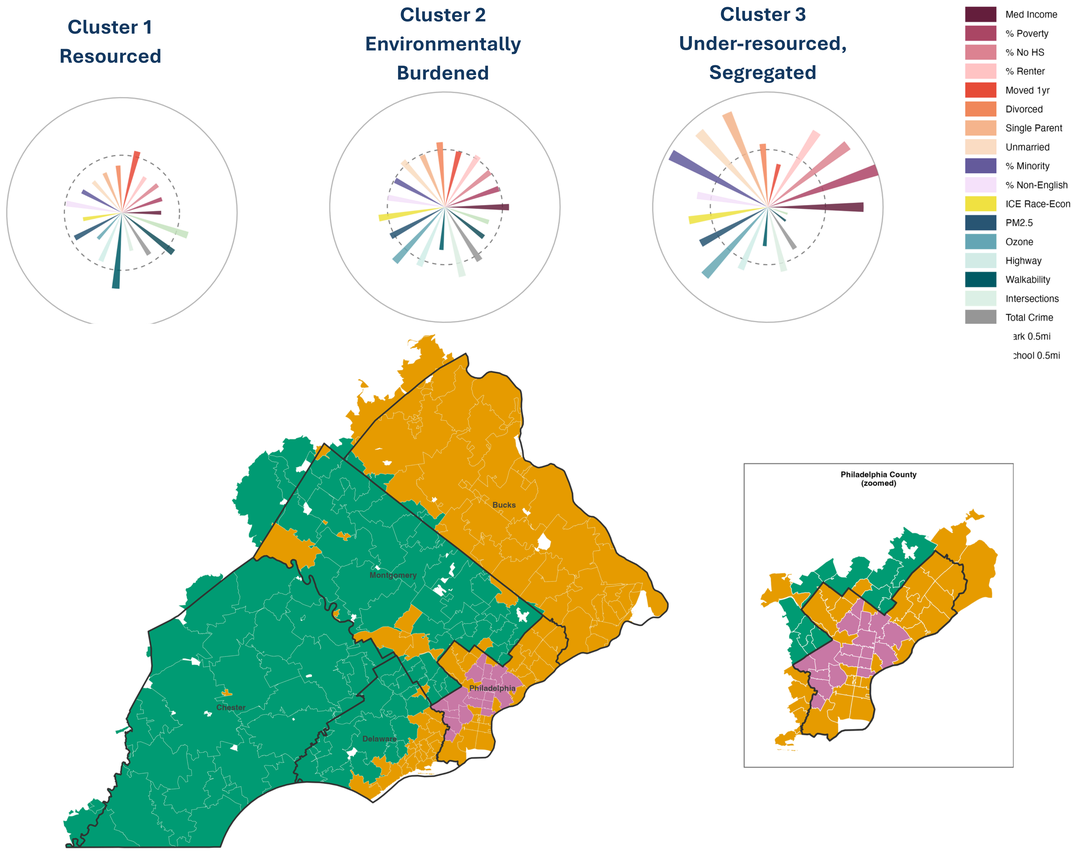
Study Population
- 16,152 adults across 5 Philadelphia-area counties
- 61% female, 68% White, 66% aged ≥50 years
- Southeastern Pennsylvania Household Health Survey, 2016–2018

Neighborhood Context
- Self-organizing map (SOM) identified neighborhood profiles

Mental Health Outcome
- Compared diagnoses across neighborhood profiles
- Adjusted for key sociodemographic and healthcare factors

Transportation Pathway
- Tested transportation difficulty as a **mediator** of the neighborhood–mental health relationship

RESULTS



Key Findings

FINDING 1: NEIGHBORHOOD DISPARITY

23% HIGHER ODDS of mental health diagnosis in under-resourced, segregated (Cluster 3) vs. resourced (Cluster 1) neighborhoods (OR 1.23, 95% CI 1.04–1.46)

FINDING 2: MODIFIABLE PATHWAY

~17% OF THE GAP statistically accounted for by transportation

FINDING 3: STRUCTURAL INEQUITIES

63% Black, 68% lower-income, and 27% college-educated among adults in under-resourced, segregated neighborhoods (Cluster 3)

DISCUSSION

Neighborhood mental health disparities may partly operate through **everyday barriers** that are **potentially modifiable**.



Improve Transportation Access



Bring Care Closer



Transit-Friendly Schedule

Address neighborhood barriers to mental health

LIMITATIONS

- **Cross-sectional** design.
- **Self-reported** mental health diagnosis.
- Statistical mediation **does not establish causality**; transportation should be tested prospectively.

MORE DETAILS

Full Abstract

Contact Me

- We thank the participants of the Southeastern Pennsylvania Household Health Survey for contributing to this research.
- The Yale University Institutional Review Board reviewed and approved this study.